



YOU ARE **28 WEEKS AND 2 DAYS**

82 days to go...

YOUR BABY TODAY

This image shows a chin-on-the-chest position with an arm held up to the side of the face. A knee is just visible to the left of the image with a loop of umbilical cord above it. Your baby now is likely to be in a head down position but there's still time to change.

“The coiled umbilical cord connects your baby to the placenta, their life-support system until birth.”

Most umbilical cords grow to be about the same length as the baby (although there are exceptions), reaching a final length of 20–23.5 in (50–60 cm). The umbilical cord has up to 40 turns along its length. These turns are seven times more likely to twist to the left than the right. The coiling pattern was in place nine weeks after conception, with more coils at the baby's end than the placental end; this may be a response to your baby's movements. The cord contains three blood vessels: two arteries taking deoxygenated blood and waste from your baby to the placenta and one vein carrying oxygen-rich blood from the placenta to the baby. The cord diameter is usually less than $\frac{3}{4}$ in (2 cm) and the blood vessels are embedded in and protected by a layer of jelly. The watery composition of the jelly, and with the cord's coiling pattern, prevents compression of the cord.

At the [20-week scan](#), they will check that the umbilical cord has three vessels. In 1 percent of pregnancies, there is only one umbilical artery. When this happens, you'll need extra scans to monitor your baby's growth

ASK A DOCTOR

If my baby has a low birthweight, will he have health problems? A low birthweight is less than 5½ lb (2.5 kg) and although the majority of small babies thrive, some do have difficulties. Most low birthweight babies are small because they are premature. There are many ways you can reduce the risk of your baby being a low birthweight: eating adequate amounts of healthy food to gain the right amount of weight (see [How much weight will you gain?](#)), not smoking or drinking alcohol, reducing stress, and attending all of your prenatal appointments.

RESTLESS LEGS
